

Xylem Pipeline Relay

Move water uphill like a tree, faster and cleaner than rival teams.

Win condition: Most water delivered with speed, low spill, and strong explanation.

THE SCIENCE YOU ARE USING

Capillary action. Water climbs narrow spaces on its own. Water molecules stick to a surface (adhesion) and to each other (cohesion), so a thin column is pulled upward against gravity. Narrower channels and more wettable materials pull water higher and faster. Trees use this in their narrow xylem, but on its own it lifts water only about a meter. To reach the treetop, water evaporating from the leaves (transpiration) pulls the whole column up, like sipping through a straw.

Material and geometry. A felt strip, a cotton wick, and a folded paper towel each move water at a different rate. Path length, slope, and contact area all matter. Your team picks the material and the route to deliver the most water to a target cup.

HOW TO BUILD AND RUN IT

- 01 Test three wick materials.** Dip paper towel, cotton, and felt into colored water. Watch which climbs fastest and highest.
- 02 Pick a material and route.** Choose your wick and lay out a path from the source cup up over a block to the target cup.
- 03 Run the first transfer.** Start the wick and time how much water reaches the target in the time limit. Catch spills in the tray.
- 04 Reduce spill and length.** Trim the path, improve contact, and re-run. Less spill and a shorter path usually deliver more.
- 05 Final delivery round.** Run the best design for score. Water delivered, speed, and low spill all count.

Safety: Work over a tray and wipe spills immediately so the floor stays dry. No standing on chairs or stacked furniture to build height. Use washable food coloring; it can stain skin and clothes, so wear gloves if you do not want stained hands. No goggles are needed for moving water.

MATERIALS

Paper towels	shared (about 1 roll)
Cotton string	3 per team (12 in wicks)
Felt strips	3 per team (16 total)
Cups	2 per team (8)
Food coloring	shared (washable)
Trays	1 per team (4)
Elevation blocks	1 per team (4)
Rulers	1 per team (4)

YOUR PLAN AND DATA

Clean, complete data is worth as much as a fast result.

Prediction (what will work best, and why): _____

Wick we chose (paper towel / cotton string / felt) and why: _____

The ONE thing we changed for the redesign (path length, slope, contact, or material): _____

Water delivered: baseline _____ **after redesign** _____ **spill** _____

DEFEND YOUR DESIGN

What evidence made you change your design? _____

If you ran it again, what is the ONE thing you would change? _____

HOW YOU SCORE (100 POINTS)

SCORING CRITERION	POINTS
Water delivered	40
Speed	20
Least spill	15
Design explanation	15
Redesign gain	10
Total	100